



BEFORE

In May 1864, as Ulysses S. Grant began operations against Robert E. Lee, other Virginia campaigns were getting underway.

BUTLER'S ARMY OF THE JAMES

In April, a new army of over 30,000 soldiers was formed under Benjamin Butler. Its task was to sail up the James River, land south of Richmond, and **cut the Richmond-Petersburg railroad**.

SIGEL'S FORCES IN THE VALLEY

On May 2, General Franz Sigel began advancing up the [Shenandoah Valley](#), where Stonewall Jackson had defeated him two years earlier. Sigel was to cut the railroad leading to Richmond, while also preventing **Confederate reinforcements from reaching Lee**.

CONFEDERATE OPPONENTS

In April, General **P. G. T. Beauregard** became commander of forces in **North Carolina and Virginia south of the James River**. Lee selected General **John C. Breckinridge** to confront Sigel in the **Shenandoah Valley**.

On the morning of May 5, when Union general Benjamin Butler landed on the Bermuda Hundred peninsula between the Appomattox and James rivers, he had a chance few generals are ever offered. His Army of the James was halfway between two key Confederate cities—15 miles (24km) from Richmond and 8 miles (13km) from Petersburg—which between them could muster a garrison of only 5,000 militiamen. What was more, the new commander of the garrison, General P. G. T. Beauregard, had still to arrive from Charleston.

Yet Butler missed his opportunity. Although he did send tentative probes out to the Richmond–Petersburg Railroad, he spent too much time and energy making sure that he was thoroughly entrenched at his new base. The Confederates, meanwhile, were using the time to pull in reinforcements from everywhere they could, and General Beauregard arrived to organize them.

When Butler did move ponderously against a target, Beauregard took him by surprise. On May 16, Butler attacked batteries at Drewry's Bluff, which commanded a bend in the James River and had long been the bane of Union gunboats. In a vicious battle in a tangled, swampy, foggy pinewood—a battle that saw bodies piled high outside makeshift breastworks—Beauregard nearly succeeded